TRADE IN TRANSITION

A 2025 REFLECTION AND THE ROAD TO 2030

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As 2025 draws to a close, global trade stands at a historic crossroads. The post-pandemic years have transformed supply chains, realigned geopolitical loyalties, and deepened the strategic assertion of the Global South in a system once dominated by Western economies. From BRICS expansion to the US's turn toward tariff nationalism under a second Trump presidency, trade has once again become a language of power, one that speaks not only of markets but of identity, sovereignty, and global influence.

The rise of South-South trade and BRICS+ influence

Over the past year, BRICS+ nations have accelerated efforts to redefine the terms of South-South cooperation. Intra-BRICS trade surpassed US$500 billion in 2024, with members such as China, India, and Russia expanding preferential agreements across Africa, Latin America, and the Middle East. The inclusion of Iran, Egypt, the UAE, Ethiopia, Thailand and other partner countries has diversified both the bloc's energy base and its political leverage in global forums. South Africa, as both the African voice in BRICS and a key player in the G20, has increasingly positioned itself as a bridge between the developing and developed worlds.

While the Global South advances integration, the broader global trade landscape has become more fragmented. The reimposition of US tariffs on Chinese goods in 2025, framed as an attempt to "re-shore American jobs", has reignited debates about protectionism and the politicisation of trade. The European Union, meanwhile, continues to double down on carbon border adjustment mechanisms, effectively taxing imports from industrialising economies in the name of green policy. For emerging nations, this signals a future in which trade will be increasingly shaped by sustainability criteria, digital compliance, and regional resilience rather than pure liberalisation.



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Fragmented globalisation and South Africa's multilateral moment

Still, this shift may not be entirely regressive. As multilateral institutions like the World Trade Organisation (WTO) grapple with stalled reform, regional frameworks such as the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), Mercosur-ASEAN cooperation, and BRICS+ currency and settlement initiatives suggest a future where trade governance becomes more plural and less hierarchical. South Africa's multilateral moment, reflected in its dual leadership roles in BRICS+ and the G20, demonstrates the growing agency of medium-sized powers in shaping inclusive trade norms that prioritise equitable growth and technology transfer.

Predictions for 2030: Regionalisation, digitalisation, and green trade

Looking ahead to 2030, three trends are likely to define global commerce. First, regionalisation will deepen, and supply chains will continue to shorten as nations prioritise security over efficiency. Second, digitalisation and the AI-driven trade ecosystem will reduce transaction costs and enhance cross-border visibility, giving smaller economies greater access to value chains. And third, sustainability-linked trade instruments, from carbon credits to green bonds, will become key determinants of competitiveness.

Trade, therefore, is no longer merely an economic function but a political instrument, a means of asserting vision in a multipolar world. For the BRICS+ community and the Global South at large, the challenge of the next five years will be to turn strategic solidarity into structural reform. The world is rebalancing. By 2030, the direction of that balance will depend on how courageously the South continues to trade, not only in goods, but in ideas, technologies, and trust.